Top 10 Things Every Parris Island *Graduation Family Needs to Know*

Three days, two ceremonies, one brand-new Marine. The timing, the gate, the picnic, and the parts nobody tells you — from a family who has sat in those bleachers.

WHY THIS LIST

Your recruit has spent 13 weeks learning exactly what to do and when. Your family gets a packet in week 9 and a lot of questions. This guide fills the gap: what happens Wednesday through Friday, what to bring to the gate, how to actually get time with your Marine, and where to feed eight people in Beaufort afterward.

Every time and rule below comes from the Depot's own visitor pages — confirm the schedule in your packet, since all times are subject to change.

3
DAYS FAMILIES ARE ON BASE

9:50
FAMILY DAY SIGN-IN DEADLINE (AM)

5 hrs
THURSDAY LIBERTY WITH YOUR MARINE

20
MINUTES FROM DOWNTOWN BEAUFORT

01 Confirm the Date, Then Book Early
02 It's a Three-Day Week
03 Thursday Is the Day You Get Your Marine
04 Liberty Is On-Base — Pack a Picnic
05 Bring the Right ID (2026 Rules)
06 Friday: Colors, Ceremony, Done by 10
07 Dress for the Weather
08 You Can Leave With Your Marine
09 Feeding a Family of Eight in Beaufort
10 Give Yourselves One Beaufort Hour

- On the Depot
- In Beaufort

Schedules, gate procedures and security measures change. Your graduation packet and the Douglas Visitors' Center are the final word.



BEFORE YOU LEAVE HOME

Plan Early, Arrive Wednesday

1

Confirm the Date, Then Book by Week 3 *The Biggest Mistake*

LODGING · FLIGHTS · TIMING

Your recruit's graduation date is set the week they ship, but the official packet with the battalion commander's invitation doesn't arrive until around week 9. Families who wait for it find Beaufort's few hundred rooms and homes already taken for that Friday. Book a refundable stay and flexible flights as soon as you have the ship date, then relax when the packet shows up.

> **INSIDER TIP** Holiday-week cycles graduate on a Monday–Wednesday schedule instead of Thursday–Friday. If your Marine's date lands near Thanksgiving, Christmas or July 4th, double-check the days before you book.

2

It's a Three-Day Week, Not One Morning *The Schedule*

WEDNESDAY ORIENTATION · THURSDAY FAMILY DAY · FRIDAY GRADUATION

The Depot is open to families Wednesday through Friday. Wednesday is Family Orientation Day: the Marine Corps 101 "Behind the Scenes" tour runs 10:00–12:30 (reservations required, check in by 9:30) and the Family Orientation Brief is 1:30–2:30 at the Douglas Visitors' Center. Thursday is Family Day. Friday is graduation. Plan to be in Beaufort by Tuesday night or Wednesday morning.

> **INSIDER TIP** Do Wednesday's tour even if it feels optional — it's the only chance to see the squad bays and the training areas, and it makes Thursday's stories make sense.

WHERE TO STAY · HATTIE'S PLACE, BEAUFORT

The graduation house: 4 bedrooms, sleeps 9, 20 minutes from the gate.

Walk to downtown Beaufort for dinner, park four cars on site, and pack Thursday's picnic from a full kitchen with a table for ten. Built for exactly this week.

Family Day Picnic Kit for 9 · Walk to Downtown · Parking for 4 Cars · Book Direct

[booking URL TBD]

Scan or visit to see availability



THURSDAY

Family Day & Liberty

3 Thursday Is When You Get Your Marine *Family Day*

MOTIVATIONAL RUN 7:00 AM · CEREMONY 9:30 · LIBERTY 10:00–3:00

The Motivational Run starts at 7:00 a.m. on Peatross Parade Deck — your first glimpse of your recruit in months, running past with the whole company. The Family Day ceremony follows at 9:30, and liberty begins at 10:00. The Depot staff use the sign-in list to locate recruits who have visitors waiting, so register at the Douglas Visitors' Center **before 9:50 a.m.**

> **INSIDER TIP** The DVC opens at 6:00 a.m. Be through the gate by 6:30 for the run; the Beaufort County Sheriff's Office warns traffic backs up on the causeway from 7 to 9.

4 Liberty Is On-Base Only. Pack a Picnic. *Our Best Tip*

THURSDAY 10:00–3:00 · RECRUITS MUST REMAIN ON THE DEPOT

Your new Marine cannot leave the Depot during Thursday liberty, and every family on base is trying to eat at the same handful of spots at the same time. Bring a cooler lunch from Beaufort instead and spread out on the lawn: more time together, better food, no line. If you'd rather buy on base, the MCX food court, Traditions, Brig & Brew and Java Café are the options, and Java Café takes pizza and wing pre-orders for Family Day.

> **INSIDER TIP** We learned this at our own nephew's graduation — the picnic families had an extra hour with their Marine. Keep it alcohol-free and glass-free, and leave the cooler closed for the vehicle search.

THE FAMILY DAY PICNIC CHECKLIST · FEEDS 9

PACK

Cooler → Blankets → Chairs

Two coolers with ice, two big blankets, four chairs for the grandparents, service for 12, two gallon jugs, paper towels, wipes, trash bags.

BUY THE NIGHT BEFORE

Deli → Fruit → Ice

About 2 lb of deli meat, two loaves, cheese, fruit, chips, cookies and two bags of ice feeds nine. Publix on Robert Smalls Parkway is on the way to the gate.

RULES

No Glass · No Alcohol

Keep the cooler closed for the vehicle search, skip glass, and remember your Marine can't drink on liberty. Pack out your trash.



Security, Colors & the Ceremony

5 Bring the Right ID to the Gate *2026 Gate Rules*

REAL ID OR PASSPORT · REGISTRATION · INSURANCE · RENTAL AGREEMENT

Every visitor 18 and older needs a REAL ID–compliant license, a U.S. passport or another federal credential, plus the vehicle's registration and proof of insurance (and the rental agreement, if it's a rental). Since spring 2026 vehicles are searched at the gate and ID is checked on foot before you drive through. Foreign nationals need a SECNAV 5512/1 on file ahead of time. No firearms, no ammunition, no pets — service animals only.

> **INSIDER TIP** Put every adult's ID and the car documents in one envelope on the dash the night before. Questions on prohibited items: Provost Marshal's Office, (843) 228-3444.

6 Friday: Colors 7:45, Graduation 9:00 *The Ceremony*

BARROW HALL · PEATROSS PARADE DECK · BLEACHER SEATING

Morning Colors is at Barrow Hall at 7:45; the graduation ceremony starts at 9:00 on Peatross Parade Deck and runs about an hour. Bleachers face the deck, there's no limit on how many guests you can bring, and no parking pass is needed — use the parade deck lot or the lot beside the Visitors' Center. Arrive at the gate at least an hour before anything you want to see.

> **INSIDER TIP** Never walk across the parade deck, even after the ceremony ends. Free wheelchairs are available at the Visitors' Center for grandparents who'll need one for the walk from the lot.

THE GATE ENVELOPE · READY ON THE DASH

EVERY ADULT

REAL ID or Passport

A REAL ID–compliant license, U.S. passport, or other federal credential for everyone 18 and over. Foreign nationals: SECNAV 5512/1 on file first.

THE VEHICLE

Registration → Insurance

Current registration and proof of insurance; the rental agreement if it's a rental. Expect a trunk and cabin search.

LEAVE AT HOME

Firearms Firearms · Pets · Vapesmiddot; Ammo Firearms · Pets · Vapesmiddot; Pets

No firearms or ammunition, no pets (service animals only), nothing you'd rather not explain. Questions: (843) 228-3444.



WHAT TO WEAR, WHEN TO LEAVE

Dress, Weather & Going Home

7 Dress for the Weather, Not the Marine *What to Wear & Bring*

CASUAL IS FINE · BATTALION COLORS · HEAT APRIL–SEPTEMBER

There's no dress code beyond common sense: no profanity on clothing, no bare midriffs, and very comfortable shoes — you'll walk more than you think. Many families wear their Marine's battalion color (red for 1st, yellow for 2nd, blue for 3rd) or a custom shirt with the platoon number. From April through September the Depot warns of extreme heat and humidity; October through March, 7:00 a.m. on the parade deck is cold.

> **INSIDER TIP** Hat, sunscreen, a refillable water bottle and a light jacket cover every month of the year. Leave the big umbrella; a poncho is easier in the bleachers.

8 You Can Leave With Your Marine *Going Home*

LIBERTY 10:00 AM FRIDAY · UP TO 10 DAYS OF LEAVE

Once the ceremony ends, your Marine is on leave — up to 10 days before reporting to Camp Geiger for combat training — and can walk off the Depot with you. Don't book a Friday flight before about 4:00 p.m.; between the crowd, the gate and the airport drive (Savannah about an hour, Charleston about 90 minutes), it's tight. Many families stay Friday night in Beaufort and celebrate properly.

> **INSIDER TIP** Walk on your Marine's left. Their right hand needs to be free to salute every officer you pass on the way to the car.

GETTING HERE · BEAUFORT IS NOT NEAR ANY AIRPORT

FLYING

SAV 1 hr → CHS 1.5 hr

Savannah/Hilton Head is the easy one at about an hour. Charleston is about 90 minutes. Hilton Head Airport is closest but has few flights. All three have rental cars.

DRIVING

Charlotte 4 hr · Atlanta 4.5 hr

Most families drive. Jacksonville about 2.5 hours, Columbia 2.5, Raleigh 5. I-95 to Exit 33, then US-21 straight into Beaufort.

FRIDAY DEPARTURE

Not Before 4 PM

Ceremony ends by 10, the gate takes a while, and your Marine wants lunch. A 4 p.m. SAV flight works; a noon one does not.



OFF BASE

Beaufort, After the Ceremonies

9 Feeding Eight in Downtown Beaufort *Big Tables, Walkable*

BAY STREET & THE WATERFRONT · CALL AHEAD FOR PARTIES OF 6+

Beaufort's downtown is small, historic and walkable, which is wonderful until 2,000 graduation visitors want dinner at 6:30 on a Thursday. For groups, call ahead: Plums and Panini's on the waterfront for a casual celebration lunch, Q on Bay for barbecue that feeds a crowd, Old Bull Tavern and Breakwater for the nicer Thursday dinner, Saltus River Grill for the water view. Magnolia Café or Herban Market for a Friday breakfast before the gate.

> **INSIDER TIP** Book Thursday dinner the same day you book your lodging. The Marine can't join you Thursday night, so make Friday lunch the celebration meal instead.

10 Give Yourselves One Beaufort Hour *Decompress*

WATERFRONT PARK · SPANISH MOSS TRAIL · HUNTING ISLAND

The week is emotional and the days start at 6. Plan one hour that isn't about logistics: the swing benches at Henry C. Chambers Waterfront Park at sunset, a walk or bike ride on the Spanish Moss Trail, or — if you stay Saturday — the lighthouse and the boneyard beach at Hunting Island State Park, 30 minutes east. Your Marine has 10 days of leave; the first afternoon of it is best spent doing very little.

> **INSIDER TIP** Wednesday evening is the quiet one. Walk Bay Street before the crowds arrive Thursday, and get the family photo under the live oaks while everyone is still rested.

YOUR GRADUATION WEEK AT A GLANCE

WEDNESDAY

Orientation → Bay Street

Check in at the DVC by 9:30, tour 10:00–12:30, brief 1:30. Shop for Thursday's picnic on the way home.

THURSDAY

Run 7:00 → Liberty 10–3

Sign in before 9:50. Picnic on base, museum, photos. Family dinner downtown without your Marine.

FRIDAY

Colors 7:45 → Graduation 9:00

Gate by 7:00. Ceremony done by 10. Celebration lunch on the waterfront, then home — or one more night.

Congratulations to your Marine, and to you. Independently produced by Hattie's Place / Assured Comfort Homes, LLC; not affiliated with the United States Marine Corps, MCRD Parris Island, or any business named here. Schedules, gate procedures and security measures are set by the Depot and change without notice — your graduation packet and the Douglas Visitors' Center, (843) 228-3650, are the final word.